

Transitions & signal words - Study Guide

Use transitions to identify the exact relationship between ideas and choose wording that expresses that relationship clearly.

Learning goal

Explain what a transition signals and select a transition that accurately connects two ideas in context.

What this skill really means

Transitions are relationship signals. They tell readers whether the next idea adds information, contrasts, gives a result, provides an example, shows sequence, or qualifies what came before.

A transition can be grammatically possible but logically wrong. The relationship between the ideas controls the answer.

Strong readers often decide the relationship first - contrast, cause, example, addition - and only then choose the transition.

Relationship	Useful signals	Question to ask
addition	also, furthermore, in addition	Is the next idea adding another related point?
contrast / concession	however, although, nevertheless	Does the next idea differ from or limit the first?
cause / result	therefore, as a result, consequently	Does one idea follow because of the other?
example	for example, for instance	Is the next idea a specific case?
sequence	first, next, afterward, finally	Is the writer showing order?

Relationship	Useful signals	Question to ask
clarification / restatement	in other words, specifically	Is the writer explaining or narrowing the previous idea?

How exam-style questions ask it

- What relationship does "however" signal between the two sentences?
- Which transition best completes the sentence?
- Why does the author use "for example" at the beginning of paragraph 3?
- Which phrase best shows that the second idea is a result of the first?

A reliable method

1. Ignore the transition for a moment and read the two ideas.
2. Say the relationship in one word: addition, contrast, cause, result, example, sequence, clarification.
3. Choose a transition from that relationship family.
4. Insert it and reread the sentence for logic and grammar.
5. Reject transitions that sound smooth but express the wrong relationship.

Tips and shortcuts

- Meaning first, transition second.
- "However" does not simply mean "new sentence"; it specifically signals contrast or qualification.
- Cause/result transitions require evidence that one idea follows from another, not just that they happen near each other.

Worked examples

Example 1

The city planted young trees along the avenue. _____, summer surface temperatures were lower on the shaded blocks.

1. Which transition best completes the sentence?

- A. For example
- B. As a result
- C. In contrast
- D. Meanwhile

Answer: B

The second sentence presents an effect linked to the planting, so a result transition is needed.

Example 2

The repair workshop is free to attend. However, participants must register because space is limited.

2. What relationship does "However" signal?

- A. The second idea gives an example of free attendance.
- B. The second idea qualifies the first by adding a restriction.
- C. The second idea shows a result caused by the first.
- D. The second idea repeats the first.

Answer: B

The workshop is free, but registration is still required. The transition signals a limitation or contrast.

Common traps

- Choosing a familiar transition because it sounds formal.
- Using therefore when the second idea is only an additional fact.
- Using however when the ideas actually agree.
- Confusing an example with a result.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, name the exact relationship between the target wording and the larger text. Point to evidence for that relationship, not just a familiar label.

Quick check

1. Which relationship is signaled by "for instance"?
2. What should you decide before choosing a transition from the answer options?
3. Why is "therefore" wrong when two sentences are merely related but not causal?

Quick check guidance

Explain the relationship in plain language before using a technical label. If your explanation works only as a summary, ask what job, purpose, perspective, or effect is still missing.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: Two transitions sound grammatical, so you choose by instinct.

Try: Name the logical relationship first: contrast, cause, result, example, addition, sequence, or concession.

2

If: You read only the sentence containing the blank.

Try: Compare the idea before the transition with the idea after it. The relationship lives between the sentences.

3

If: You treat near-synonyms as automatically interchangeable.

Try: Check nuance and grammar. A transition must express the right relationship and fit the sentence structure.

30-second reset

Before the next transitions & signal words question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.